reported that India planned to talk about the Indo-Pacific with both Russia and China.[25] At the Shangri-La Dialogue, Modi also spoke of transformed ties with Japan and described the Indo–Japanese partnership as a cornerstone of India's Act East Policy. He recalled the strong momentum of India's ties with the Republic of Korea and the fresh energy in partnerships with Australia and New Zealand. He introduced a new phase of engagement with the Pacific Island countries and of meetings of the Forum of India-Pacific Islands Cooperation (FIPIC).

In defining the Indo-Pacific, Modi emphasised ASEAN centrality: that the Indo-Pacific has Southeast Asia at its centre and that ASEAN would be key to future regional peace and security. He referred to both the East Asia Summit and the Regional Comprehensive Economic Partnership as important regional initiatives that have India as a partner, and he referred to his idea about Security and Growth for All in the Region (SAGAR). On military-to-military ties, he emphasised that India has had uninterrupted naval exercises with Singapore going back a quarter century, that a new trilateral exercise with Singapore and other ASEAN countries would soon start, and that mutual capabilities would be built with partners like Vietnam.

Modi elaborated upon his vision of the Indo-Pacific a year later at the 14th East Asia Summit. He said that the summit was the logical platform to promote a free, open, inclusive, transparent, rules-based, peaceful, prosperous Indo-Pacific region, where sovereignty and territorial integrity and "the application of international law especially UNCLOS are assured to all States equally." He added that the Indo-Pacific should be a space in which freedom of navigation; over-flight; sustainable development; protection of the ecology and the marine environment; and an open, free, fair, and mutually beneficial trade and investment system are guaranteed to all. Specifically, he proposed an Indo-Pacific Oceans' Initiative for working collaboratively to safeguard